

The Axolotl That Wouldn't Grow Up

Name: _____

Date: _____

Year 5 English — Reading

ACARA v9.0: AC9E5LY05

Learning Intention

I am learning to interpret and evaluate an informative text, including how ideas are developed and supported with evidence.

Success Criteria

- I can identify key information and its purpose in the text.
- I can explain cause-and-effect relationships in the text.
- I can evaluate ideas using evidence from the text.

The Axolotl That Wouldn't Grow Up

Most amphibians, like frogs, go through a dramatic transformation as they grow — starting life in water with gills, then developing lungs and legs to live on land. The axolotl, a strange and fascinating salamander native to lakes near Mexico City, breaks this rule entirely.

Axolotls stay in a permanent "juvenile" state their whole lives, a phenomenon scientists call neoteny. Instead of losing their feathery external gills and moving onto land like most salamanders, adult axolotls keep their gills, remain fully aquatic, and even retain a tadpole-like appearance well into adulthood — including their distinctive wide smile and feathery head-fringes.

What makes axolotls even more remarkable is their extraordinary regenerative ability. If an axolotl loses a limb, its tail, or even parts of its heart, brain or spinal cord, it can regrow that body part almost completely, often with no scarring at all. This ability has made axolotls one of the most studied animals in modern medical science, as researchers hope to understand how axolotls achieve this and whether similar regeneration could one day help human medicine.

Despite their scientific fame, wild axolotls are now critically endangered. Their native habitat, the canals and lake remnants around Mexico City, has been severely damaged by pollution, urban development and introduced fish species that prey on young axolotls. Some estimates suggest only a few thousand wild axolotls remain, and some surveys have found none at all in recent years.

Ironically, while wild axolotls face extinction, the species is thriving in laboratories and as pets around the world, meaning the axolotl's future may depend far more on human-controlled environments than on its natural home.

Part A — Comprehension Questions

Q1. Where are axolotls native to? _____

Q2. What is the scientific term for staying in a permanent juvenile state? _____

Q3. True or False: Axolotls are currently listed as critically endangered in the wild. _____

Q4. What body parts can an axolotl regenerate, according to the text?

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Part B — More Comprehension Questions

Q5. Why are axolotls important to modern medical science?

Q6. Name 2 reasons wild axolotl habitats have been damaged.

1. _____ 2. _____

Q7. What is ironic about the axolotl's situation, according to the final paragraph?

Part C — Challenge: Think Deeper

A conservation group is deciding whether to focus their limited funding on restoring the axolotl's natural habitat, or on expanding captive breeding programs in laboratories.

Q8. Using evidence from the text, explain one advantage and one disadvantage of each option.

Q9. Explain why the text describes the axolotl as 'breaking the rule' that most amphibians follow. What effect does this comparison have on the reader?

Q10. Evaluate whether you think it is more important to save an endangered species in the wild, or to ensure the species survives at all (even only in captivity). Justify your view using ideas from the text.

Answer Key — Part A & B

A1: Lakes near Mexico City.

A2: Neoteny.

A3: True — wild axolotls are critically endangered.

A4: A limb, its tail, or even parts of its heart, brain or spinal cord.

A5: Researchers hope to understand their extraordinary regenerative ability and whether similar regeneration could one day help human medicine.

A6: Pollution and urban development (accept introduced fish species preying on young axolotls).

A7: While wild axolotls face extinction in their natural habitat, the species is thriving in laboratories and as pets around the world.

Answer Key — Part C

C8: Habitat restoration: advantage — protects the species in its natural ecosystem; disadvantage — pollution/development damage may be difficult or slow to reverse. Captive breeding: advantage — more directly guarantees survival of the species; disadvantage — doesn't address or fix the wild habitat problem (accept similar reasonable points).

C9: It highlights how unusual the axolotl is compared to typical amphibians, drawing the reader's attention and curiosity by framing the axolotl as an exception to a well-known pattern, making its unique traits feel even more remarkable.

C10: Accept a reasoned answer either way, as long as it references evidence from the text (e.g. habitat damage risk vs the species already thriving in captivity) to justify the chosen position — teacher to check reasoning quality, not the position itself.